INDIA TODAY
www.indiatoday.in

CHAIRMAN AND EDITOR-IN-CHIEF: Aroon Purie
VICE CHAIRPERSON AND EXECUTIVE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF: Kalli Purie
GROUP CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER: Dinesh Bhatia

GROUP EDITORIAL DIRECTOR: Raj Chengappa

CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER: Manoj Sharma

GROUP CREATIVE EDITOR: Nilanjan Das; **GROUP PHOTO EDITOR:** Bandeep Singh
EDITOR (FEATURES): Kai Jabir Friese
MANAGING EDITORS: Sunil Menon, S. Sahaya Ranjit, MUMBAI: M.G. Arun
EXECUTIVE EDITORS: Manisha Saroop, Kaushik Deka
SENIOR DEPUTY EDITORS: Sangram K. Parhi; HYDERABAD: Amarnath K. Menon
DEPUTY EDITORS: Sasi Nair, Anilesh S. Mahajan;
JAIPUR: Rohit Parihar; MUMBAI: Suhani Singh
SENIOR EDITORS: Pradip R. Sagar, Ashish Mukherjee;
PATNA: Amitabh Srivastava
SENIOR ASSOCIATE EDITORS: Sonali Acharjee, Sonal Khetarpal, Saikat Niyogi,
MUMBAI: Dhaval. S . Kulkarni, AHMEDABAD: Jumana Shah, BHOPAL: Rahul Noronha
ASSOCIATE EDITOR: Avishek G. Dastidar, BENGALURU: Ajay Sukumaran
SENIOR ASSISTANT EDITOR: Vipul Grover; **ASSISTANT EDITOR:** Harshita Mishra
SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT: LUCKNOW: Prashant Srivastava;
KOLKATA: Arkamoy Datta Majumdar
PHOTO DEPARTMENT: Chandra Deep Kumar (Deputy Chief Photographer),
Rajwant Singh Rawat (Principal Photographer);
MUMBAI: Mandar Suresh Deodhar (Chief Photographer)
PHOTO RESEARCHERS: Prabhakar Tiwari (Deputy Visual Research Editor),
Saloni Vaid, Jodha Singh Adhikari (Principal Photo Researchers)
CHIEF OF GRAPHICS: Tanmoy Chakraborty
ART DEPARTMENT: Sanjay Piplani (Creative Editor);
Angshuman De (Senior Art Director); Rajesh Kumar Angira (Associate Art Director)
Bhoomesh Dutt Sharma, Santosh Kumar Sharma (Assistant Art Directors),
Praveen Kumar Gummadi (Chief Designer); Siddhant Jumde (Chief Illustrator)
PRODUCTION DEPARTMENT: Harish Agarwal (Chief of Production),
Naveen Gupta (Chief Coordinator)

SENIOR ASSOCIATE PUBLISHER (IMPACT)
Suparna Kumar

IMPACT TEAM
Senior General Managers: Mayur Rastogi (North and East), Jitendra Lad (West)
General Managers: Syed Naveed (Chennai), Arup Chaudhuri (Bangalore)
GROUP CHIEF MARKETING OFFICER: Vivek Malhotra

SALES AND OPERATIONS
Deepak Bhatt, Senior General Manager (National Sales)
Vipin Bagga, General Manager (Operations)
Rajeev Gandhi, Deputy General Manager (North)
Yogesh Godhanlal Gautam, Deputy Regional Sales Manager (West)
S Paramasivam, Deputy Regional Sales Manager (South)

INDIA TODAY GROUP

Volume 49-Number 4; For the week
January 16-22, 2024, published on every Friday

● Editorial/Corporate Office Living Media India Ltd., India Today Group Mediaplex, FC-8, Sector-16A, Film City, Noida - 201301; Phone: 0120-4807100
● Subscriptions: For assistance contact, Customer Care, India Today Group, C-9, Sector-10, Noida (UP) – 201301. email: wecare@intoday.com; Phone / Whatsapp: +91 8597 778 778 (Monday to Friday, 10 am – 6pm).
● Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, C-9, Sector-10, Noida-201301 (UP)
● Regd. Office: F-26, First Floor, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001.
● Impact Offices: 1201, 12th Floor, Tower 2 A, One Indiabulls Centre, (Jupiter Mills), S.B. Marg, Lower Parel (West), Mumbai-400013; Phone: 022 69193355; Fax: 66063226
● E-1, Ground Floor, Videocon Towers, Jhandewalan Extn, New Delhi.
● Door No: 610, 610A, 612, 5th Floor, Block A, Imperial Chaitanya Building, Anna Salai, Teynampet, Chennai, Tamilnadu-600018.
● 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; ● 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22825398; Fax: 22827254; ● 6-3-885/7/B, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 ● 39/1045, Karakkatt Road, Kochi 682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058 ; Fax: 2377059 ● 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293 ● Copyright Living Media India Ltd. All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited.

Printed and published by Manoj Sharma on behalf of Living Media India Limited. Printed at Thomson Press India Limited, 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana) and at Rajhans Enterprises, 134, Industrial Town, 4th Main Road, Rajajinagar, Bengaluru-560044, (Karnataka).

Published at F-26, First Floor, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001.

Editor: Raj Chengappa.

● INDIA TODAY does not take the responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material.

All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent courts and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only

SYNDICATIONS TODAY INDIA DELIVERED
For **reprint rights** and **syndication** enquiries, contact syndications@intoday.com or call +91-120-4078000
www.syndicationstoday.in



Photo Illustration by NILANJAN DAS

COVER STORY

THE PREMIUM PHENOMENON

Rising incomes are pushing middle-class Indians to choose fancier, pricier products in their quest for a better lifestyle

INSIDE

UPFRONT
BENGAL: WITH FRIENDS LIKE THESE... PG 6
BILATERAL TIES: THE FRENCH CONSOLIDATION PG 15

LEISURE
CINEMA: AN EPIC OEUVRE PG 51
Q&A WITH ADARSH GOURAV PG 60

VEHICLE SCRAPPING
36 SLOW START
The ambitious policy runs aground as states are tardy and private players hesitant

ANDHRA PRADESH
42 SIBLING RIVALRY
CM Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy faces a challenger in sister Sharmila, who has joined the Congress

BULLET TRAIN
46 SPEEDING AHEAD
With land acquisition completed, India gets ready to welcome its maiden bullet train

Note to the reader: From time to time, you will see pages titled 'An Impact Feature' or 'Focus' in INDIA TODAY. This is no different from an advertisement and the magazine's editorial staff is not involved in its creation in any way.

INDIA TODAY GROUP

Readers are recommended to make appropriate enquiries before sending money, incurring expenses or entering into commitments in relation to any advertisement appearing in this publication. The India Today Group does not vouch for any claims made by the advertisers of products and services. The printer, publisher, editor-in-chief and the editor of the India Today Group publications shall not be held liable for any consequences in the event of such claims not being honoured by the advertisers.

SCAN HERE TO SUBSCRIBE

FOR SUBSCRIPTION ASSISTANCE, CONTACT: Customer Care, India Today Group, C-9, Sector-10, Noida (UP) - 201301. email: wecare@intoday.com | Phone / Whatsapp: +91 8597 778 778 (Monday to Friday, 10 am - 6pm)

E-MAIL to: **letters.editor@intoday.com** or log on to **www.indiatoday.in**